Paper Crowns

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Arranged Marriage, Secret Identity, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), catra is in love with adora, Catra thinks Adora is dead, Past Relationship(s), Everyone is despressed, Second part of Lover, Ball time but they are in the middle of an intergalactic war, Everyone Needs Therapy, vengeance, Threats of Violence, She-Ra loses her shit a little bit, Kisses, Lots of sexual tension, but they won´t act on it, Complicated Relationships, Depression, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Soulmates, implied suicide ideation, but it won´t come to that, they love each other very much, Someone is being an asshole and Catra and Shera are a power couple, Mild Hurt/Comfort

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Part 2 of Ruins of War

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Paper Crowns

by StarryNap

Summary

"And still, you won´t lay in bed with me?"
"No"
"Why not?"
Because I love you. Because I won´t be able to control myself if I have you in my arms.

The second part of "Lover." She-Ra and Catra go to a ball in the middle of the war. Secrets of the past bite on their ankles and their loyalties shift closer to each other as this marriage becomes into something they both need to breath.

Notes

Welcome, welcome! It´s been a while since I saw you here. I bring you now the second part of this series, diving a little further into absolute CHAOS and ANGST

But in reality, we are a little bit more easy going here than before. The girls are slowly starting to trust each other further. Also, I really needed to write something where She-Ra defends her wife and where Catra shows how important and smart she is by herself. It´s a need!

Please remember that this is a second part and that you WILL need to read the first one to understand what is going on. Just in case you are new here <3

Hope you enjoy and I´ll see you downstairs!

See the end of the work for more notes

Paper Crowns

"Devil," you call me, but seems to be enjoying
The fruits of my labour that came to me too young (...)
For if I'm going down, I guess I'll take you with me
Screaming birds sound an awful lot like singing
And I will tell you now, that I'm not even singing
There's no escape for some
– **The Fruits**, *Paris Paloma*

—— ⋆·☆·⋆ ——

"Would you do it the same?" Sheets rumpled on legs, feverish skin, hands against freckles, the linger of a kiss on the back of her neck. "If you knew, what was going to happen. Would you do it the same?"

"No." Fingers against damp hair, scars over palms, corners of eyes sore by past tears. "If I had an opportunity to do it all again, there would be no power in the universe capable of ripping me away from you."

—— ⋆·☆·⋆ ——

Many moons before

Adora is dreaming. This she knows.

"Adora"

It is always the same. It starts the same and runs its way through the curse of the night. Like moon cycles about to collide. Etheria, wonderful, quiet, bright Etheria. Twisted trees of the Whispering Woods cradled in blues and purples; evergreen grass, pink sky, stars in the sky and moons falling towards the orbit. Falling, always falling down, the ground cracking in the middle and lightning breaking the forest into blazing fire. A portal of green light that consumes it all into nothing, plain, silent nothing. The void.

“Adora”

Then it changes, it transforms, new images born from the destruction of her home. A planet where she breathes air for the first time, a place she does not know. Open windows, golden cribs, fresh air. The humming of a woman lullabying a baby to sleep and then her screams, high and terrified, a mother being ripped off her child. Consequences beyond her control. Devastation of war.

“Adora”

The screams chase her, pull her apart, draw her near and then far away until she is here again, in the empty space. And then it transforms again, like a sandworm to a moth, a cocoon broken by tooth and claw and Adora is not the same anymore. Blinding white light, a portal, different kinds all breaking her heart. She hovers on air, high platforms of metal against the bleeding red sky. Hard floor, colder air and there, standing on the very edge like an angel about to take fly, golden and sapphire eyes.

“Adora”

Adora can see her, plain as day even under the dark, the moons hiding the sun in the middle of the day. Against red sky and polluted air or next to lilac night and shimmering stars. In the woods, in the desserts, among golden riches and stolen fabrics as tents.

Brown is her hair like damp earth, curled never tangled, falling over the elegant back. Soft skin even below scars and sun burns, freckles and moles and stretch marks like nebulas over the naked universe. Long fingers, sharp nails. The fall of strong shoulders, the soft curve of tender breasts below white worn-out fabric. She, this woman Adora loves, stands between the limit of the world and the void of space, threatening to devour her whole. Open lips, red, long ago not kissed, moving, whispering, weaving their way through the letters of her name.

“Adora”

Palms of hands, falling at the sides of lean legs. Red, red. Red. Palms coated in fresh blood, dripping off from the elbow to the wrist to the palm to the long fingers and nails, staining the white into crimson. Hers. Theirs. Catra's. Adora´s. Their joined blood, painting red blooms on the snow below her soles.

“Adora.” Tears, everlasting, sharp as swords across Adora´s heart. Arms around her neck, mouth over her eyelids, the cold edge of a sword pressing through Adora´s chest. A stab wound done by who she loves the most, bleeding her to death. “Stay”

In the dream Adora opens her mouth but no sound comes out. In the dream Adora extends her arms and fights to cradle her inside but she does not reach in time.

“Adora”

“Adora,” Sheets ruffled to the side and a hand on her shoulder, yanking her painfully awake. “Adora!”

Adora rises with a gasp, already in motion. Her hand slips below the cheap pillows and grabs the handle of her always nearby knife, unfolding it in one swing. It swings inside her palm expertly and cuts the air with a silent motion, resting the lethal sharp edge over the throat of the person hovering over her.

Glimmer holds her breath, her short pink hair fluffing up, eyes wide with shock. Her hands are up, a calming motion done as a reflex by Adora's response, but her fingertips are cracking the start of magic ready to try and push away Adora if necessary. Adora exhales slowly through her mouth, recognition making it´s way down her body as the haze of the dreams go away completely, bringing her back to be present.

“Glimmer,” Adora whispers, slowly lowering the knife back down, shame and guilt pooling on her throat and choking her.. Glimmer sighs, light sweat clinging to her forehead but relaxing again. She

is standing next to the frail couch Adora had crashed into, the room dim under the shadows of the covered windows.

That's right, they are not in Brightmoon anymore –they are not in Adora´s dreams – Instead, they are in the bulky and impersonal rooms of the Crimson Waste´s headquarters, a shoebox kind of room that is still bigger than Adora´s space back in the Horde. The room is cold but the small rays of sun that creep below the thick metal curtains are wavering, testimony of burning heat beyond the walls of the crooked building. It was not strange, after all they were in the Crimson Waste and nothing green or fresh ever grew here, the days were always burning and merciless, so hot that if you are not careful the heat will eat you alive. And if it doesn´t, the sand definitely will, silent killer.

Adora drops the knife back into the bed, resting her sweaty face between her palms. The light fabric of her shirt and pants is perfect for the heat of the desert but her heart drums out of control and her body steams for very different reasons, bright blue eyes shimmering in the dark, almost drowning out the white of her scleras. In a way, they are not different from Catra´s, broken jewels mirroring each other.

"I´m sorry Adora. It's been half an hour like you asked." Glimmer says softly, her voice on edge. She is obviously displeased by how little Adora is resting but she is also a regent and she knows they need She-Ra now, not Adora. And Adora needs at least a second of rest before slipping back into the puppet show. "The Waste Herald was already in my room calling for the meeting. We need to get going."

Glimmer turns around in the reduced room, leaving a long piece of paper over the frail table on the corner. An invitation to Huntara ´s Meeting that is almost a mockery of the ones that once upon a time were delivered for the Princess Prom. It really does feel like a whole lifetime ago, it hurts as much still.

When Adora closes her eyes she can still see Catra´s face on the balcony of the Frozen palace, throwing herself towards Sh-Ra´s

throat, her freckles pale, patches of red lightning burns coloring her neck, witnesses of Shadow Weaver´s violence beyond the stage of the Horde. It still makes Adora´s blood boil inside her veins.

Adora lets her head roll backwards, releasing the air inside her lungs with a long sigh of boiling steam, rising like clouds inside the room. The transformation happens quickly, twisting and changing Adora, pulling from bone a muscle and every cell and atom of her skin until she is made of light itself, space steel and stardust lingering over her body as a second skin. From the girl tethering in madness to a saint cradled in white robes.

This time, however, her clothes are different than usual. The undergarments of her armor are thinner, stopping her body from overheating. Tunics of flax fall down her shoulders and arms, shimmering with starlight sparkles and moved softly by invisible breeze. Breastplate, wrist gauntlets and the silver chainmail remain the same, twinkling softly with each movement. As always, her hair is short, pushed back by the heavy golden headpiece, pristine skin and bright blue eyes.

“I know the mood is incredibly tense right now and I know you are doing your best, so please try to keep the peace.” Glimmer says back in the corner, wrinkling her nose apologetic. “With Salineas and Plumeria fallen, we can't risk it with Huntara. We need whatever piece of First Ones machinery she found.”

“I know,” She-Ra answers, standing from the small couch.

She stares at Glimmer in silence as her friend goes in and around inside the room, collecting things quickly. She is already dressed, the skirt of her simple dress tangling around her leather pants, armored in the chest and face clean from the dirt and sand gathered after hours of travel in the desert. She looks anxious, rushed even, her wings fluttering every once in a while and making her fly off the ground a few inches each time.

“Are you leaving early for the meeting?”

“Um, no,” Glimmer stops near the door, her breath hitching in her throat. She is barely twenty one, a year younger than Adora herself, yet she looks older. Worn down and exhausted by the loss and the war. “I promised to Catra that I would help her with her clothes”

The words are a warhammer against She-Ra´s chest. She feels the pain of it crossing her heart, tethering her back and threatening her to crumble her down in pieces. In a way, she is thankful. She knows Glimmer has become Catra´s friend, that the torture and the fear in Prime´s ship brought them closer; that the bitterness and goodness they both share make them tender around each other.

She-Ra knows that Catra saved Glimmer, and that without Glimmer Catra wouldn't have survived Prime´s mental torture. It ´s a debt She-Ra, Adora, will never be able to repay to Glimmer. She knows they are friends and that Glimmer cares and attends to Catra in ways She-Ra cannot. She is grateful.

It still hurts. It still kills.

“Oh,” She-Ra can hear herself saying, a broken whisper in the middle of the room. Glimmer´s eyebrows knit together in worry, stepping closer to She-Ra´s space with a sad look in her eyes.

“Adora–”

“I'm not Adora anymore.” She-Ra´s voice cuts the tender moment, high and devastatingly firm. She can see the way the words break Glimmer´s heart but she doesn't dare to dwell into her own suffering a single second more. Instead, she tries to breath softly through her nose, mustering a small smile that doesn't reach her eyes. “You should go with her, she gets really impatient when she is nervous.”

Glimmer opens her mouth, ready to say something, but she thinks it better and closes it back down, nodding instead.

“Alright.”

“Glimmer?” She-Ra takes Glimmer´s wrist between her fingertips, calling her friend´s attention once more before letting her go completely. “Take care of her?”

Glimmer´s entire expression melts at the silent desperation in She-Ra´s voice. She knows, too, even if Adora has never expressed it completely out loud. Glimmer knows just how deep Adora´s devotion for Catra runs.

Glimmer rests her palm against She-Ra´s shimmering cheek, nodding gently. “Of course, love.”

Glimmer will never speak about it, but she can feel the gentle run of clear tears coating her fingertips. It breaks her heart too. She didn´t understand the burden hanging over both of these women's shoulders until Prime´s ship and by then it was entirely too late to stop the suffering.

“We´ll look after her. That´s a promise.”

—— ⋆·☆·⋆ ——

The air was cold the day Prime´s green light broke the sky in two again.

Etheria was quiet, as ever since the first apparition on the new-coming spaceships, hovering right above the atmosphere like threats of falling meteors about to fall down against the earth. White and green, dots of machinery hiding again the long ago lost stars. It had been such a long time for the etherians to see that shimmer again, clustered among the void and darkness of Despondos, that for the first hours when the ships arrived they believed them to be a gift too. A lie.

The first time Prime appeared in the sky, huge form, fluttering hologram body, he was congratulating them, congratulating Etheria. After hundreds of years lost, it had finally found its place back in the Universe. Back to a place choked and dying underneath Prime´s hand. He did it all with a smile on his face,

laughing, like the priest of some temple that whispers promises of paradise but delivers punishments in return.

He did it all as his forces lowered into the ground and took the former Fright Zone by surprise. Even far away, in Drill, in the broken door of Salineas, in the hidden mountains of BrightMoon, even there it was seen, the green fire consuming it all. Yellow sparks, undying fire that no water or sand could put out. Even there the kingdoms and the scared villagers of the towns could listen to the screams as dozens of Horde soldiers ran scared and overpowered, trying to escape the chase of the clones. The blasters against chests or the mind numbing chips against the back of their heads.

Even there, on the highest point of the castle where the Moon Stone shone, Adora could hear it, the echo of yells. She could see it, the bloodshed. She could smell it, the smoke, ashes falling over Etheria like rotten snow. Even where she was, battered and in pain after Weaver's attack, Adora could see as the bright light stole Glimmer, and then there was silence and Adora knew nothing else for months.

She-Ra was advised not to go. Not to walk among the fire and look but she couldn't be stopped. And nobody else but her could have made it through the fire alive anyway. So she went to the remains of what once had been a home, twisted and terrible yes but a home after all.

She looked below every rock, every huge piece of wall fallen, every jarred pipe of metal, every patch of ground burnt into pieces, every glass and fabric and oil consumed. And She-Ra was screaming but Glimmer´s name was not in her tongue, nor in her teeth or the back of her throat. Instead, there was another name, yelled at the top of She-Ra's lungs. Screamed and screamed until the magic almost dissolved Adora´s mortal body beneath She-Ra ´s armor and still, there was no answer.

Catra was not there. Catra was gone too.

She-Ra is a goddess. She is a superior being; a princess, a queen; a spirit of Etheria, a myth; a warrior a saint. She is brave and just. She is perfect and unyielding. She doesn´t break no matter what.

Adora is different, Adora is full of fire and she is full of anger. Adora is full of passion and desire long ago buried in the depths of her soul. Adora is full of want, want for freedom – her own. Full of Catra. In every little corner and sharp edge of her soul and spirit, in every inch of her mortal or divine skin, there is Catra. Adora is full of fear and regret and vengeance that night, looking among broken pieces of the world as Etheria stopped shaking from being pulled by She-Ra´s hands off the voids of the Universe.

She-Ra would be smart, quiet like a panther, always ten steps before. She would take the remaining Prime Clones under her hold and make them talk, prey every inch of information that she can out of them until she knows everything that there is to know about Prime and Glimmer´s disappearance. She would form a plan and make that plan. That´s why she is the chosen one after all, that´s why she was taken from her home again and again. Because that is who she is supposed to be.

The Adora that thinks that, after all the pain and sacrifice, has lost Catra? The Adora that walks inside their destroyed bunk beds and finds her room under ashes? The one that catches pieces of her forgotten headpiece on the floor and smells the lingering sandalwood and blood out of it? That Adora is brutal, and she kills them all, one by one.

She is not even She-Ra when she does it. She sees the crimson drops on the red metal and all she can see is red, all she can smell is metal, all she can do is scream until the clones are nothing but the green mockery of blood and the metal in pieces is the mirror of butchered flesh on the ground. This Adora would have break the very universe in the middle, into pieces, if it weren't for the last try of humiliation from one of the clones, speaking about the Horde Leader being taken alongside Glimmer too, refusing to leave the Princess side, exchanging herself for the life of the Horde soldiers that managed to escape into the woods.

She-Ra remembers the cold nights and the freezing mornings, being unable to sleep. Refugee camps and empty castles; war reunions with the remaining members of the Rebellion. Stretching herself to the impossible to be She-Ra as long as possible, every second of the day. Being barely held down by Bow and the new found King Micah and Castaspella. Yelling at the sky above, unable to travel to space to get Glimmer back. Unable to protect Catra, again.

It was a surprise to everyone when Glimmer appeared in the sky, when She-Ra barely caught her before falling down where her wings failed her. She was alive, beaten up and scared, but alive.

And the first thing she did when opened her eyes was grab the ethereal fabric of She-Ra´s armor and whisper at her, tense and panicking. Catra, saved me, she had said, holding back tears because Glimmer knew now, she understood everything now. She saved me. She said she didn't have anything else to lose, that she wanted to be with you– with Adora. And she saved me. And when She-Ra choked on her own breath too, Glimmer cried a little. Get her out of there.

She-Ra remembers that day as clear as water; as well as she remembers every single day that came after. As well as she remembers the night the dark sky opened into green again and Prime spoke to the world and then to She-Ra only. A gift, for you. A proof of my devotion to your world.

She-Ra, Adora; princess and traitor; a friend and a lover, she remembers Catra´s blood soaking the ground of the Whispering Woods. She closes her eyes and can see the frail curve of her body over the grass, white and gray clothes so different from her usual attire. Matted hair and panting, in pain, agonizing breaths after being thrown from the ship to the ground like a pearl falling from a cliff.

She-Ra remembers running through the circle of clones already waiting for them, a poorly disguised trap meant to humiliate her further. The smell of copper blood and green drops on the earths

as her sword cut and sliced the metal and wires like silk, without resistance, down and down until it was nothing but broken pieces. And even if it was meat instead of metal, she would have not stopped, crawling her way over the ground until she reached Catra, finally gathering her inside her ethereal arms after years of pushing her away.

How could she not remember it, how could she ever forget it? The feeling of Catra´s life slipping through her fingers like sand. Barely managing to save her and unable to erase the past pain.

She will always close her eyes and see in the back of her eyelids the way that, for a second, Catra was gone before she took a shuddering breath back to life, staring at She-Ra´s face stained in green blood and soaked with tears hovering above her like some kind of cruel angel.

The way that, when Catra´s comprehension started to make way inside her mind, her precious eyes widened terrified, running her claws over the bodysuit, begging She-Ra to take it out. Out. And the way herself, She-Ra, with more mortal strength than goddess ripped the fabric in pieces with her bare stands and held Catra´s bare body against her chest. Naked skin over warm armor, running her fingertips over Catra´s back and shoulders and legs until every single wound and scar disappeared completely, absorbed by Adora´s mortal body underneath She-Ra.

Adora will always remember the way that, for a second, she thought Catra could see, see Adora, beyond the layers of magic and war and pain, that she would recognize her beyond the immortal skin, holding Catra against her chest in the same way Adora did thousands of times on the Horde. But Catra didn´t.

In a way, Adora thought it was fitting. There was too much blood on her hands. She was cursed to live for this holy war and die by its blade. Heroes, martyrs, didn't get to be happy. The only thing she could do for Catra now, the only way to truly protect her, was to win the bloodshed and give her a world of peace, even at the cost of her own death.

She-Ra is staring at the huge war room beyond the almost closed curtains that separate it from the thin corridor right now.

As usual with every room of the twisted castle of the Crimson Waste, there are dozens of exits on the walls, barely covered by the thick black curtains that are meant to give it more privacy. That is what happens when you try to make a castle out of stolen parts of machinery and scraped remains of old buildings. It's the best that can be done right now, with everything.

She is staring at the people walking in and around with narrowed eyes, her arms crossed tightly over her chest, memories cluttering her mind as she stares without really seeing at the Waste´s people and the princesses of the Alliance, each on their own groups, each snaring at each other from the corners, distrustful and weary of each other even after everything.

Glimmer and Bow are doing damage control with the Alliance, trying to convince them to give the first step and fall into the diplomacy they are meant to be doing. It doesn't seem to be doing good though, and the heat and sand slipping inside through the crooked but huge windows isn't helping either.

She-Ra chews on her own cheek and molars, annoyance slipping through her veins when a Wasterian crashes accidentally with an ambassador of Salineas and, instead of use it as the start of a conversation, they scowl at each other, high chins and scoffs as they both walk away away. She-Ra truly, really, does not want to be here right now.

“Not a fan of parties?” Catra´s voice echoes inside the small corridor, ripping She-Ra out of her thoughts immediately.

She didn't hear her arrival but that is not a surprise. Catra has always known how to slip quietly when she wants, since they were children. She-Ra should have known however; if she wasn't so distracted with her own personal war battling inside her mind she could have maybe caught the smell of her approaching her, so familiar and so dear to her heart.

She-Ra closes her eyes for a second and shakes away the bitter images playing below her eyelids, giving herself a single moment of mercy before turning around to face Catra fully, mouth open to answer. She falls quiet immediately after, though, unable to form a single word in her tongue at the sight of Catra barely inches away.

All of her hair has been held into a thick braid, falling long and regal down her back, the dark strands held in place by golden rings. Her head and nape are tucked inside a fine chainmail, so delicate and soft that it feels like silk, the edges crowning her forehead and temples with opals, hanging from her ears like teardrops. The shimmering jewels make her eyes look like the twin moons on the etherian sky, sharp and thick dark eyeliner that makes the freckles in her cheekbones look like stars.

She is wearing a tight tunic, high neck and long sleeved that opens to the sides of her hips, letting see the fabric of the leggings below that hug themselves to her ankles and soles by leather cords. All black, perpetually in mourning, except for the talli on her tunic that shimmers golden under the dim lights, moons and stars embroidered softly on the wrists and waist.

There is an armor chest held to her torso, of a metal so fine yet so strong it looks like waved into the very fabric of the clothes, wrapping itself over her ribs, heart and neck, protecting her from harm and somewhere inside She-Ra she is thankful, because she knows this is Glimmer´s doing.

A long veil is wrapped around her head, falling down her neck and crossing on the shoulders until it opens like a cape made of flax down her back and calves, of a red so deep that looks like fresh blood or spilled wine.

Like this, only her eyes and red mouth are visible, bright stars in the middle of the darkness of the corridor staring at She-Ra in silence. Her presence is quite yet overwhelming, filling the entire space with her smell and her breathing, her bright eyes weighing She-Ra carefully and her sad mouth.

She-Ra stares at her and finds herself out of words, her ethereal breath tangling inside her throat and her voice gone, gone, stolen like air for a single look of Catra in front of her. So close, so far away.

“Catra,” She-Ra manages after a long second, gulping heavily. Catra notices the way in which she looks at her, her face melting too into something She-Ra cannot read. It has been such a long time since She-Ra could read Catra´s expressions fully, it is tragic.

“I don't like sand in my hair,” Catra says after a beat, as if the whole reason She-Ra had been left speechless were Catra´s clothes and not the fact she is the most beautiful creature She-Ra has ever laid her eyes into.

Catra walks towards She-Ra, stopping right next to her by the frame of the corridor. Her arm is just a few inches away from She-Ra´s, the latter can feel the warmth irradiating out of it like a sun but still she doesn´t get closer and they do not touch. Separated by a fine veil of tragic between them

“Tell me why I'm here again,” Catra mutters between her teeth, staring at the same scenes She-Ra had with her nose wrinkled.

Her freckles shimmer a little and she smells so good. So beautiful, sandalwood and incense and flowers. She-Ra closes her eyes and feels herself leaning towards her head, taking a breath out of her scent before she even realizes what she is doing and snaps her face away, closing her hands into tight fists over the handle of the sword hanging from her hip.

“You are a Princess now and an active member of the Rebellion.” She-Ra says, carefully but firmly, tilting her head to the side to look at Catra´s beautiful profile through her eyelashes. “You are Royalty”

Catra´s entire face wrinkles, fighting herself against the repudiation cursing through her veins at the titles. Never in her whole life Catra would have imagined she would become a

Princess, out of all fucking things. This She-Ra knows. She knows just how much she is fighting herself internally against the words and the meaning of them, coming to the other side with a blank stare.

Maybe She-Ra has not forgotten how to read Catra after all.

“Names given by Queen Sparkles for joining forces with all of you,” Catra spats, narrowing her eyes. She points at the ball´s floor with her chin, towards the Royalty with their sneers and pointed up noses. “The Royal Court won't see me as part of them. Never”

She-Ra holds her breath for a very different reason than gathering Catra´s smell on the back of her throat. She looks at the ball full of people distrusting each other, heat and sneers and shakes her head once, pressing her lips into a fine line when she looks at Catra again.

“They will because you've earned it”

Catra blinks and turns towards her, her eyes dark where her pupils blow up without her permission and this is the first time in these minutes that She-Ra notices the way Catra´s cheeks are flushed as she stares at her but her face remains so proud. She-Ra adores her completely.

“I destroyed their homes for three years. The Horde has spilled their blood under my command,” Catra says, words falling easily from her red lips yet She-Ra sees the way they wear her down, weighing over her like the world hanging from her shoulders.

It is a feeling She-Ra knows well, it is a feeling she never wished for Catra to carry.

“The Alliance has caused just as much destruction and death,” She-Ra answers back, her thick eyebrows knitting together with displeasure. “We are not better. We never have been.”

Catra´s eyebrows skyrocket on her face, her mouth falling open a slit. She composes herself quickly but it is obvious the words have shaken something inside of her. She-Ra wishes she could dive her way inside her ribcage and wrap her arms into her warm heart and shelter her from it all.

She-Ra says nothing else and Catra does not comment on it but she gets imperceptible closer to her, the smell of her skin filling She-Ra´s nostrils even as she towers over her. In the faux ballroom there is music playing, low and a little out of tune, completely different to the cheerful music She-Ra got to hear in her first years as a General of the Rebellion, when the towns were still thriving and the people liked to throw parties. This one is sadder, almost like a mockery.

"Is the whole show necessary?" Catra whispers after a while, crossing her arms over her chest. She-Ra clicks her tongue over her teeth and looks outside too,

"Princess Huntara was very specific about her requests." She-Ra narrows her eyes, searching for the wide back and white hair of the self proclaimed princess among the weary people of the Waste. "Only like this she would agree to meet the Rebellion, I guess she got tired of not being recognized as leader of the Waste. Considering all things, she has been most welcome. The other princesses are very grateful"

It´s a lie. She-Ra knows it and Catra knows it too. Both of them can see the faces of the other princesses staring at Huntara. Up and down, with a sneer. Even with a chuckle some when they catch the worn out fabric with which Huntara has made her formal clothes and the harsh body below, full of scars of the war and the roughness of the sand.

The princesses are all softness. Silk on their clothes and precious metals on their wrists and necks. Jewels on their armors and crowns on their foreheads. They are regal and precious in all ways, colorful like a long ago lost rainbow, sparkling like the new found sky scattered with stars.

The wasterian are so much different from them. Rough in the edges, worn out by the war. Exiled, forgotten, forsaken. These are the people that have come to wander on the sand and the treacherous mountains that shift and sink every night and dawn. They are cut for conflict and to always be defensive, always ready to be stabbed in the back. Catra knows these people well, she was one of them at some point when she thought death was a mercy and the heat burnt new freckles on her skin.

"And yet, she is still referred to as the bastard Princess of the Crimson Waste behind the closed doors of the Rebellion." Catra whispers, snapping, cutting like a whip against the air. It is full of charged grudge, of venom, spilling through Catra´s white fangs and into the floor.

She-Ra sinks a little under the weight of her voice, all godly shimmer shivering at the sound of Catra´s disapproval. At the knowledge that she cannot correct her. She knows damn well what Catra is thinking too, she feels it too, she feels the hypocrisy in her very bones, in her very skin.

"She self proclaimed–

"She is not different to me," Catra cuts her, closing her eyes for a second. She-Ra closes her mouth so fast that she bites herself, inhaling quietly through her nose.

You are different, she wants to scream. I am too, she wants to howl. Neither of them were born like the princesses, neither of them were raised royal and untouchable.

They both know about cold floors and harsh words and killing training. They both knew about blood before they knew about softness. Razz can tell her that she has always been a princess all she wants, ripped from a golden crib, brought to this world to save it and herself. She-Ra can be Etheria´s goddess the rest of her godforsaken life, but inside of her she will always be a stray.

But for the world, for the universe, She-Ra is only light and her humanity has long ago died. She cannot say anything else.

Catra exhales heavily and opens her eyes again, hooded eyelids as she stares at the ballroom. There is something dancing in her eyes, precaution maybe, maybe also some kind of weary feeling inside herself too, born from a time of her life that She-Ra does not know.

"I can deal with Huntara and with the princesses. But the people of the Waste– they won´t see me kindly," Catra confesses, tugging from her sleeves. Nervous, she is nervous and it throws She-Ra off.

"Have you been here before?" She-Ra asks, tilting her entire body towards her. Catra looks at her sideways but doesn´t meet her eye, nodding softly before answering.

"Once," Catra´s voice is hoarse, her chest heavy with a gasp. "It wasn´t good"

Some kind of darkness spreads inside She-Ra´s chest, heavy, overwhelming, choking her from the inside out. It blooms from this new found knowledge, that there are so many things Catra went through when she was not there anymore. That Catra was here at some point when she was younger, here in a place that once was a threat of punishment for the cadets between the barracks of the Horde.

That Catra carries with suffering She-Ra does not know and cannot carry for her. That dims her down and makes her afraid, even here, even now that she is protected with everything She-Ra has to give. It makes She-Ra angry and it makes her want to scream.

"You are my wife, Catra." She says between the shadows, finally meeting Catra´s eye when she turns to look at her surprised. She-Ra frowns, her entire golden face darkening like an eclipse. "I will not allow for anyone to disrespect you"

Catra´s face blooms too, with something much different than hatred. Knowledge, surprise, intelligence. Desire.

She licks her lips and doesn´t move from her place, allowing She-Ra to tilt her whole body towards her instead.

"Would you do it?" Catra asks, out of breath, searching her way across every faction of She-Ra´s impossible face. "Would you do that for me?"

"Say the word and I will give it to you."

She-Ra knows that this is dangerous. That she is walking on a very fine line, promising Catra things that she shouldn´t. But She-Ra has already taken so much from Catra and gave her so little in return. Why would She-Ra have to hold back, to not give Catra anything her heart desires, when She-Ra carries this world in the palm of her hand?

Catra blinks, considering the true weight from the words. Would She-Ra fight for her? Yes. Would She-Ra kill for her? Unknown, dangerous. Would She-Ra give her life to Catra? Yes, yes.

Is it guilt? Is it desire too? Want? Catra sees inside her opal eyes and sees nothing but raw devotion and it makes her want to fly and want to die. She doesn´t even notice it yet but Catra carries the universe inside her palms because anything she needs She-Ra will give it to her.

How frightening. How exhilarating.

"Kiss me," Catra asks for instead because for some reason all Catra wants from She-Ra is not blood or stars or war. She wants her life, her heart, her mouth. She wants it. She has it already.

She-Ra does not hesitate and she doesn´t step back. She is sure and practiced like when she is in battle, known steps, known warmth, known lips. She is the one that moves, twisting her body so her back covers Catra from any curious eye beyond the

shadows, cradling her freckled face between ethereal hands and pressing their mouths together.

It´s not the first time, it´s not the first night Catra asks her this. She does it after meetings, after battles. on the secrecy of shadow or her bedroom door. Ever since that night, she opens her mouth against She-Ra´s and meets her cold tongue with hers, allows her to run it across her sharp teeth, digs her fingertips on She-Ra´s neck and doesn´t even cut down, careful too now.

It's bittersweet and heavy, sore like a throat ache and wanted, so very wanted above anything else. It steals She-Ra off her breath and places it inside Catra´s chest and, honestly, sometimes that is the only reason why she keeps breathing into this world.

She-Ra parts from her with a heavy chest, thumbing the damp corner of her mouth with a touch so gentle that it takes them both by surprise. Catra´s red lipstick is now in She-Ra´s mouth and it doesn´t even look foreign, a rose petal pressed over sensitive skin, a trace of Catra´s redness on She-Ra´s white and golden body.

Catra gulps, takes a breath and holds it inside her lungs until they ache, slipping her warm hand inside She-Ra´s cold one. She sees the moment an Alliance herald notices their presence but she ignores them, meeting She-Ra´s stargazing eyes and holding her so hard that it must hurt yet she doesn´t flinch away.

“Hold my hand,” Catra urges her, asks her, straightening her back and meeting the ballroom again with a blank face, lips kissed, heart in pieces. “You are my wife too”

She-Ra opens her mouth but she sees the herald too and quiets again, slipping back into the firm and battle cry posture she is always in. Back straight, short hair, golden crown, golden aura. Not a feeling or a stare out of place. She shifts her hold on Catra though, squeezing her fingers once in an old reassurance that escapes her and that makes Catra´s heart stop, slipping her

elegant hand inside the corner of her shoulder and holding her next to her like an equal, not a shadow.

“She-Ra,” the herald says, a little out of breath. His clothes are bright too and he does not ignore Catra like others do, instead tilting his head respectfully towards her. She-Ra has seen them before among the walls of Brightmoon, she likes him. “Commander.”

Catra hums but it is in approval, sensing the respect too. She nods back at him, her sharp nails digging a little bit on She-Ra´s steel skin when he looks apologetic at both, his eyebrows darkening his face.

“I must present you both now,” he says, almost in a whisper, almost as if he didn´t like this either. She-Ra nods, straightening her face.

“We know, go ahead.”

The herald nods once and turns around, pulling completely from the curtain until their little corridor in the shadows is no longer protected by it, orange light pouring over their faces and meeting the rest of the precarious palace. The herald clears his throat and speaks, voice loud and clear, powerful enough that it makes the whole room quiet down again, all heads and faces turning towards them.

“Honorable people, I present to you now She-Ra, General of the Rebellion and High Princess of Eternia, Saint of the Alliance´s Order. And her wife, Commander C´yra, Leader of the Horde and Right Hand of BrightMoon.”

They are looking, everybody is looking and it is horrid but they hold on into each other. She-Ra gives a step forward, walking alongside Catra into the polished floor, the heels of her boots clicking softly against the echo of the stirring music.

She-Ra. It is her. Can you believe it? She is gorgeous.

She-Ra hears some of the attendants whisper among themselves, quiet or loud even, looking at her and her golden clothes with both marveled and infatuated eyes. The members of the Alliance know her but there are minor Princesses that had never seen her in person before and they gape at her presence, face flushed and mouths watering.

That's the so-called goddess, the people of the Waste whisper on the other side, their eyes heavy, their mouths weary, rageful even. They sneer at the sparkles dug in her marble skin and the golden curling on her neck, spitting on their mouth and shivering. Shaking. Even in their resentment they cannot help but be overwhelmed by her. It is said she has killed thousands of them, the clones. But when did she ever come to our aid?

And then there is Catra. She holds her head high and does not look down a single second, her beautiful eyes locked in front of her and her hand tight around She-Ra´s arm. She is proud, unyielding, unbreakable under the eyes that follow her when they catch sight of her next to She-Ra´s shine. A natural leader, a born star from the sky.

There she is. Traitor. Traitor. Princess´s lover. Traitor

It is hatred. So much more than She-Ra´s, so much more than awe, rooted on grudge and resentment. Born from some kind of treason that the Waste felt to its bone, when Catra was much younger and wandered into these tall dunes, into these cold nights and burning days. When she was one of them and then turned around and ran towards her own pain.

Catra is untouchable. She cannot be broken by them but she is close. Catra hears their voices, it is impossible not to do so, digging past her soft body and the armor, making a home underneath her skin. She is also trembling a little bit but only She-Ra notices it, leaning her body softly towards her in an act of care that comes as easy as breathing.

Slut.

“She-Ra,” Huntara steps in the middle of the floor, opening her arms wide with a welcoming smile on her face. “Finally”

It breaks the tension inside the room like a heated sword, the sounds returning inside the room with full force. The music comes back louder and the voices rise away, still talking among themselves with wrinkled noses but at least they are looking away now.

She-Ra hums, stopping right in front of Princess Huntara and accepting the embrace without returning it fully, not letting go from Catra´s arms for one single second. She does palm Huntara in the back strongly though, holding her upper arm with a squeeze full of layered meaning.

“Huntara,” She-Ra nods in recognition, meeting her dark eyes with blue ones. “Good to see you.”

She has met Huntara before, once when Glimmer, Bow and She-Ra thought they could find some kind of First One technology that could answer their questions; back before neither of them knew about the First One's true intentions and the Heart. Back before the world was crumbling down before them.

She met her as a warrior, brave, somehow of a drunk but loyal. Important to her people. Then the Portal had broken the world in two and She-Ra had not seen her for a very long time until now, and even now they are miles different from before, both of them.

Huntara hums at She-Ra, tilting her head back a little to meet her eyes. Even with metal boots and strong armor covering her body she is still somehow shorter. The red ruby tiara on her forehead twinkles a little when she lowers her head to look at Catra standing right next to She-Ra, her white eyebrows skyrocketing on her forehead.

“And I take this is your wife,” Huntara says, smiling around the words. She looks up and down at Catra, significantly shorter than both of them and delicate like a poisonous flower. Huntara´s

eyebrows arch, her mouth twisting into a pleased grin. “I am surprised”

“You shouldn't,” Catra says for herself, cutting and sharp like a knife. She clicks her teeth together and hums, narrowing her eyes at Huntara. “I am certainly not.”

Glimmer is standing behind Huntara, next to Bow, her eyes widening with alarm when she catches the tone in Catra´s voice. She-Ra meets her eye and shakes her head softly, looking carefully as Huntara´s pleased stare melts into surprise and then shocked delight, leaning her head back and snorting with a loud cackle.

“Don't misunderstand me, your Highness,” Huntara says around an honest grin, her shimmering with approval at Catra´s dark eyes. “Tung Lashor talked to me about you. He said you were as fiery as strong, and I can see now with my own eyes that he was right.”

Catra´s heavy stare flatters a little in the edges, her mouth opening with surprise. She doesn´t even seem annoyed by the royal title Huntara had called her with, her colorful eyes shimmering with recognition at Huntara´s words.

She-Ra does not know who this Tung Lashor is, and seriously what a ridiculous name, but it seems to raise some kind of memory inside of Catra, surprise and also respect slipping in her face. Catra is careful with her expressions, she knows everyone is still observing her, but it is quite obvious for She-Ra alone that she suddenly is eager. A spark of the fire that lives inside of Catra and that She-Ra so much adores reflecting on her mismatched eyes.

“Is he here?” Catra asks, roaming her eyes around the room quickly looking for him.

Huntara´s face falls into something somber again, her mouth twisting into a grimace.

“No,” she says with a shake of the head, curling her fingers around the base of a glass full of whiskey and emoting it one go. “One of the many losses of Prime´s attacks, I´m afraid.”

“I see,” Catra says, her eyes misting for a second before throwing her shoulder back. “My condolences.”

“Of course,” Huntara blinks, regarding Catra fully. “He might be gone but he admired you and he feared you.” Huntara tilts her head towards Catra, nodding at her. “I respect that”

Pride blooms inside She-Ra´s chest at the words, not from hearing someone accept Catra but from hearing someone recognize how wonderful she is. It makes something inherently human and forever in love inside She-Ra´s chest to flutter and make roots around her heart.

Glimmer and Bow take the words as a green light too because their nervous and tight faces melt into something more relieved. They step into the conversation, smiling brightly at the self-proclaimed Princess and bringing a few representatives alongside with them, starting to make the introductions of this political and diplomatic meeting.

She-Ra is quiet, listening and firmly next to Catra, but she can still hear the poisoned comments coming from the side of the room from several Westerians, unimpressed by Catra and unimpressed by everything about her. She-Ra stares at them out of the corner of her eyes and frowns, pressing her lips into a firm line. She supposes not everyone holds Catra in the same respectful level as Huntara.

Catra and Glimmer are speaking in quick voices with a Minister of the Sea Elf Village, one of the most affected places after Salineas fall, discussing matters of trade agreements for the incoming harsh winter and war relief funds and Waste protection. Catra looks so at ease like this, so at home, shoulder to shoulder with Glimmer as she speaks firm and quick about the politics, waving

her fingers into diplomacy with smart eyes and sharp mind. She-Ra admires her so deeply.

She-Ra steps forward and rests her palm over Huntara´s shoulder, nudging her a little to the side when the latter looks back at her with a curious look.

"Huntara," She-Ra´s voice drops, accent thick as she slips into the language of the Waste. "We are friends and we are comrades. But if any of your people lay a hand or a word on my wife I will kill them and hang their heads on your door, is that clear?"

Huntara´s easy going face grows slack, her jaw hanging open. She was obviously not expecting for those words to leave She-Ra ´s mouth because she turns to look at her with eyes wide open, meeting She-Ra´s serious yet lethal with her breath held. She must realize, she surely must notice, the way She-Ra does not say the words like a threat or for intimidation, but like a promise.

"Of course," Huntara says, nodding her head slowly.

Catra chuckles at some point for a bad joke the Minister says and She-Ra snaps her head towards her immediately, drawn to the sound like a planet to a sun. Huntara follows her ethereal eyes, humming under her breath at the expression she sees nestled there.

"You know, at the beginning I thought the whole marriage thing was just another diplomatic shit show," Huntara says, still in the Waste´s language. She looks at She-Ra´s impossibly beautiful face, still held from Catra´s profile like a deity´s statue, and chuckles, nudging her with her shoulder. "I did not know your devotion for her ran this deep. Considering she tried to kill you quite a few times."

She-Ra holds her breath, making senses of Huntara´s words inside her chest. She adores Catra, of course she does, how could she not? She is the half of her soul, all of her heart, the golden thread that keeps her joined to life and keeps her alive, that is

Catra. She has been her air and her blood and her lungs since they were children and now, even among death and war, there is nothing She-Ra, goddess and warrior, holds dearest to her heart.

But the thought of other people knowing just how much she adores Catra makes her uneasy, quivering inside golden armor and magic. If Huntara has noticed so quickly then surely others have. And there are just too many people that want She-Ra dead, that want her to suffer.

What if that brings Catra more pain? Is She-Ra´s bare existence putting her at risk again?

"Come on, I have something for you and your Alliance, to ease the mood," Huntara says, unaware of the way She-Ra is spiraling inside her own head.

Huntara whistles, calling the attention of everyone inside the ballroom again. Glimmer and Catra snap their attention back to her too, waiting expectantly for what is to come. Bow has made his way at the other side of Catra, resting his palm on the middle of her shoulder blades, gently holding her when the Waste heralds started to make their way inside the conversation again.

The sight eases the chokehold in She-Ra´s throat, helping her breath. She is grateful for them, she will always be grateful. She knows they love her, she knows they will look after Catra after everything is done.

The huge curtains of the side of the room open slowly, falling into the ground in a leap of dust and ragged fabric, letting see through the huge window that leads to a second room, even bigger than this one. There is an object in the middle of the floor, big as a building and long like an opal, hovering by nothing but science and magic above the stones of the ground, illuminated by the single dome above it that showers it with purple light.

"A gift, for you She-Ra. As a symbol of peace and alliance between our people." Huntara announces with a pleased grin,

nodding at the ship with her chin.

She-Ra holds her breath, all thoughts coming to a stop. She knows this ship, she has seen it dozens of times before inside her dreams, plaguing her when the answers of a past still chasing her started to slip inside her mind. She has seen it carved on the tall walls of the Crystal Castle, on Light Hope´s more forbidden memories before she shut down forever. She has seen them in the diaries that Razz guards, drawn with steady hand and First One´s letters.

It is Mara´s ship, broken and tethering into something fragile after a thousand years hidden, fallen, still covered slightly in sand where Huntara´s people dug it out of the dunes just a few days ago, just before she agreed to help in the war.

The crowd gasps at the sight too, both Wasterian and Royalty, eyes wide open at the smooth metal and twisted letters on the surface that they cannot even begin to understand. They are all so absorbed by the sight that they don´t even notice when a person bursts from among them like a hurricane, pushing them aside with uncontained excitement.

"A spaceship!" Entrapta exclaims the second they lay eyes on the new piece of First One technology, jumping up and down their feet before rushing towards the ship without waiting for anyone else.

Bow rushes forward too, seeking to hold them back as much as he can before they start to undo all the wires and tries to repair it right here. They still have to take it home after all. But even he can´t help the expression of awe etched to his handsome face, blinking at the spaceship as if never in his life he had expected to see something like this before.

"Well, more than a gift I guess it´s a return. It has your name all over the place." Huntara comments in a lower voice, planning She-Ra on the shoulder blades before approaching the spaceship too, talking quickly with Bow about the logistics of the whole

transportation and exactly what she expects of the Rebellion in return.

She-Ra is, not for the first time this evening, at loss of words. She blinks at the spaceship in front of her, chewing the inside of her cheek. She can almost hear it, she can feel it, the tremor of past voices shivering from the ship and inside her own head, calling for She-Ra´s name over and over again, welcoming her in a way, repudiating her too.

Sister, they call her, again and again until it is not a word anymore.

Chosen one, honorable among the folk, princess of power. They repeat, tangling her chest and her head with their invisible hands like claws made out of fog.

Traitor, traitor. Mortal. How dare you fall in love?

She-Ra looks to the side, curling her fingers around the handle of the sword in a movement that is both absent and full of self reassurance. She looks to the side and finds Catra already looking back at her, her expression grave but her eyes softer, regarding She-Ra standing bright in the middle of the ballroom floor with a glint on her beautiful eyes.

She-Ra starts walking towards her immediately, like breathing, following her light. She had been holding herself back for so long, so many years of battle on opposite sides of the war and then so many months on the same castle yet so far away from the other, than now that Catra had opened the gates of her love for her to wander freely again, She-Ra had found herself unable to resist her anymore.

“That is quite the machine,” Catra says under her breath when She-Ra reaches her, looking at the spaceship and the members of the Rebellion that had approached to take a glance of it. “You must be happy to have it back.”

Sometimes, it takes She-Ra by surprise just how little Catra seems to truly know. How she still believes She-Ra is still this immortal goddess that has traveled from space and time to fight war after never ending war, never crossing her mind that She-Ra is nothing but a golden cage and that there is just mortal flesh beneath her, bleeding and ready to be sacrificed.

Sometimes it rots inside of She-Ra the realization of just how deeply she has been lying to her, how much she is holding from her to know thinking it will protect her. Sometimes the amount of her secrets makes She-Ra feel like she is betraying her all over again.

"I'm sure it will be of much better use for Entrapta than for me for now," She-Ra murmurs back to her, staring at her pretty face.

An errand curl has escaped the closed confinements of the chainmails around her head, bouncing freely against Catra´s soft forehead. She-Ra has to make a physical effort to hold herself back from wrapping her fingers around it and tuck it softly behind her twitching ear.

Glimmer cleans her throat softly next to them, ripping them both back to the present. She gives She-Ra a pointed look, full of a hidden meaning that only both of them know before slipping back into the perfectly curated face of the Queen of Brightmoon. She turns to the side lightly, resting her palm over the shoulder of a quiet man standing next to her that She-Ra had not noticed before.

"She-Ra, Catra, this is one of the Crimson Waste´s cultural ambassadors, Lord Darius"

He is a kind looking man, old, older than Micah, with soft feline factions and gray hairs over his hair. His eyes are dark gray and the patches of his fur are brown, scattered in small lines of black here and there. There are round glasses hanging from the bridge of his curved nose and regal clothes that look older than his years

yet still carefully taken care of, as if he had been saving them for many years for something important only.

The purple of his vest and the golden thread embroidered in swirls over it make the scar on his face to pop like a river over rocks, painful and long ago healed, crossing his entire left eye from forehead to chin, taking his eyes with it.

She-Ra looks at him trying to push down the surprise bubbling inside her chest, considering him quietly. She had never seen another magicat besides Catra before. Not in the Horde, not even in the three years roaming Etheria during battles and aid.

And he is staring at both She-Ra and Catra. No, not starring, gaping better said, at Catra and Catra only, his breath tangled inside his chest and his mouth fell open. He kind of looks like he is going to fall himself any second now, gripping his obsidian cane inside his claws with so much strength his knuckles pale against his bones.

“Hey eyes.” Lord Darius whispers, tilting dangerously to the side as he looks at Catra´s face. He kind of looks like he is about to cry. “Maiestas”

In front of him Catra blinks, her forehead wrinkling with confusion. She must feel just as confused and lost as She-Ra does now, and the latter knows she hates feeling like that because Catra´s forehead curls into a frown, her nose wrinkling.

“Excuse me?” Catra asks, a little bit strained, her pupils turning into large lines inside her eyes.

The Ambassador seems to finally realize Catra´s tone and the tension in the small group, because he shakes himself out of his self-inflicted stupor, clearing his throat sharply.

“I– I am sorry, you must forgive me. Your Highness, your Grace.” He says quickly, nodding his head towards Catra and then to She-Ra next to her. His cheeks have gone pale, making the scars on his face deepen against the peach fur. “It's just, it has been such

a long time since I saw another magicat. I believed we were extinct for a long time. Yet here you are now, standing in front of me and regal after all this time."

One of his ears has been completely cut in half, the butchered base ragged in the edges where it healed long ago. Still, they twitch nervously as he stares at Catra from head to toe, not judging her or studying her, but with a kind of expression that She-Ra immediately recognizes is complete admiration. Eyes soft, like a grandfather looking at a child he has not seen in a long time.

Next to She-Ra, Catra shifts on her feet, more and more uncomfortable as the seconds of silence go by. She holds herself with all her strength from stepping back a little, tuck herself behind She-Ra and snap her head away, remaining proud and beautiful and quiet the whole time.

She-Ra notices the way anxiety is building up inside her throat, though, which cannot lead to anything good. So she steps forward a little, taking the lead of the conversation for a second so Catra does not have to.

"What do you mean by extinct? If you don't mind me asking," She-Ra asks softly, absently tightening her grip over Catra´s waist.

The question is done in the most sensitive way, She-Ra´s tone tamed, but the Ambassador´s eyes still go wide at the naturally commanding inflection of She-Ra´s voice, his tail lashing back and forth behind him. He clears his throat, looking at She-Ra sideways and speechless for a second, as if he had forgotten for a second that he is the presence of a god and not any other warrior of the war.

"Of course, your Grace, I get this is not a story anybody else knows. After all, I´m the only one left alive to tell it."

Lord Darius' voice wanders off at the end, his eyes blurring sadly before focusing back again. He takes a deep breath, holding both Catra and She-Ra´s eyes on his.

"We magicats, we had a kingdom before. Just like Drill or the Kingdom of Snows. Just like Plumeria and the Scorpion Lay. Our kingdom was great and prosperous, filled with peace among each other and with Etheria, with magic and science and education. A sister of Brightmoon in a way. Halfmoon, was its name."

Catra´s pupils dilate inside her eyes, overtaking the colors like new moons hung from the sky. She-Ra holds her breath and tries very hard to remain still, studying Catra´s face swiftly before looking back at the magicat. Lord Darius' eyes are glossed over, reflecting the candles around the chamber like the stars on the dark night outside.

"Halfmoon was a green land, green as nothing you have ever seen before. A paradise beyond comparison, an oasis of culture and richness, of people and royalty as old as the very earth. Our people were wise and our technology advanced, we were in balance with the magic of this planet and it made us strong and harmonious." Lord Darius blinks around the memories, his mouth curling into a nostalgic smile. "On our glory days, one might even say that our Kingdom was even greater than Brightmoon and Salineas together, with the apology of Queen Glimmer next to me"

Glimmer blinks, astonished and obviously taken by surprise by the whole thing. Her face is a little bit pale too, matching everyone else in the group. "I– I had never heard of this before"

"Of course you didn´t, your Majesty," Lord Darius shakes his head, his nose scrunched up with sadness. "I believe there was no time for you to be let know before, rest in joy be Queen Angella, could tell you about it. And we were gone before the times where Etheria knew what war and conflict was."

Lord Darius turns to look at She-Ra´s eyes now, meeting her with a heavy stare. He kind of looks as if he was trying to tell her

something with his eyes alone, maybe even a silent plea to protect the last of what is left of his home.

“The Horde invaded us the moment that godforsaken portal opened into our ground, when Hordak and his army took the battle against the peaceful people of Etheria. It was a desperate battle on his side, they tried to take our technology, our magic. our children even. Halfmoon fought bravely but our ancestors never got to confront someone so violent and full of the need to destroy everything so they had to go into hiding after that. A lost empire that ended up to be no more than just a myth.”

Lord Darius shakes his head, giving a sip off the glass he is holding with his other hand. Catra is very tense next to She-Ra but the latter is already going into overdrive, thinking about the man´s words over and over again.

An empire, a kingdom destroyed. A home, a home for the magicats, a place from where Catra came from. A place where her culture lives, where maybe even her family is still alive, still waiting for the time to find her, to cradle her back into their arms and protect her.

And maybe, just maybe, She-Ra can give Catra so much more than just a free world. Maybe she can give her back her family too, there is a possibility now, one that she never thought possible. She can do that for her, she would be safe. She would have people that would love her when She-Ra is gone.

“Where is Halfmoon now?” She-Ra snaps suddenly, loud even in the middle of the chamber. It snaps the group's attention towards her, staring at her eager face. Catra is looking at her too, her eyebrows raised and her mouth pressed into a tight line, her nails digging softly over her own thighs at the desperate edge on She-Ra´s voice, so far away from her usual ethereal tone. “What happened to it? Can we go? Can we help them?”

Lord Darius blinks at her, his mouth fallen slack with surprise. He takes just a second to compose himself again, his face falling into

something so mournful that it shakes She-Ra´s bones to the marrow.

"Your Grace," he whispers slowly, looking at the floor covered in sand below their feet. "You are stepping on it."

She-Ra goes cold, frozen to the spot like a curse. She looks down too, the soles of her golden and white boots gathering sand in the edges. Here on the Waste, where nothing beautiful and tender grows anymore but dunes of red sand long ago tinted by blood and thorns of dry roots. Here in this place where the crimson moon washes everything in heat and the nights are deadly and unbearable.

Where you would never even begin to believe that there was green before, or barks of trunks or rip fruits falling from their cups. Where She-Ra looks at the charred and bent pieces of metal all around them, the fallen buildings and barely kept alive chambers and realizes this was once a kingdom of ever flowing waters and moonstones. A place where Catra was born before it burnt down.

"The Horde attacked the kingdom twenty years ago. Commander Hordak was seeking our magic to create a portal for the rest of his army. The Red Witch found us, found our location with rotten magic and Hordak did not doubt to let all the weight of his hand fall over us."

The Red Witch. Light Spinner, Shadow Weaver.

Words fall from Lord Darius' mouth like the tale of a nightmare, long ago over but ever present. She-Ra knows quite a lot about nightmares.

"It left nothing but blood and bones behind. Those who survived like me scattered across Etheria searching for shelter but many died in the process. I wandered from place to place until I came back to what once had been my home and found nothing but destruction and the sand of the once high crystals that formed the

palace and the Half Moon runestone. Until our magic was corrupted by the witch and our land defiled by Hordak and this place became nothing but the Valley of the Lost and, with time, the Crimson Waste."

Lord Darius looks at everyone´s faces slowly, one by one, and then settles definitely in Catra´s, staring at her pale and pretty face with eyes full of a hope so deeply rooted inside of him that is palpable to the touch.

"We have lived like this for years. Hoping for a sign of hope, any that might fall to tell us that we are not alone, that we will survive, the soul of us. The few comrades I knew have already passed away waiting for it. But now? Now I get to have the privilege to see it with my own eyes. Dea. Maiestas. Inamoratas."

He looks like he wants to reach for both Catra and She-Ra´s hands but he keeps himself respectfully away, only staring at both of them with his eyes damp by the tears. Glimmer´s mouth is hanging open and it takes her a bit too long to compose herself, her pink wings ruffled at the top where her nerves are getting the best of her.

"Well, um" Glimmer tries, choking a little on her breath. She looks to She-Ra for hellp but the latter has been left just as speecheles, so she turns towards her other friend instead, trying to be as soft as possible as to not freak her out. "Counsellor Catra?"

Catra is gone, She-Ra can see that. She is physically here, still next to the warrior, still proud and regal, but her mind is miles away and her heart is beating so hard inside her chest that it is a war drum inside She-Ra´s eardrums, loud and earthshaker.

She-Ra knows this, she knows what it means, that Catra has finally been pushed over the edge and that she is about to break down if she doesn´t get out right now. She-Ra lights her touch on her waist, unseen for anybody else but Catra feels it, snapping herself back to reality with a small gasp.

“I–” Catra starts but falls quiet again, opening and closing her mouth until her eyes harden, setting into a grave expression. “Excuse me”

She turns on her ankles and leaves, just like that, not even bidding her goodbyes or respects when she starts to beeline across the ballroom towards the other side of the place. It leaves Glimmer sputtering but she falls into manage control immediately, calling for Lord Darius' attention again to try and distract him from her.

She-Ra was already expecting it, turning on her feet too and following Catra behind quickly, reaching her immediately with her long legs and quick walk. She rests her hand around Catra´s hip and lowers her run, not stopping her but holding her anyway.

Her touch is light enough that Catra could step away if she wanted, and when she doesn't She-Ra leans towards her, pressing her mouth against her temples to whisper in her ears.

“I´m here,” she says, absorbing the shivering in Catra´s body inside her own. How wonderful and how fucking awful. Who wouldn´t wish for the She-Ra herself bidding to their requests no matter what, yet Catra is the one given that rotten privilege. Her hand over She-Ra´s heart.

Catra snaps her teeth together into a low growl but she leans towards She-Ra´s heated body anyway, melting a little inside her hands though still holding herself so tight she feels like she might splinter and break.

“I just need to get away and have a drink,” Catra whispers right back, her voice strained from how hard she is holding herself back. She doesn't even know what she wants to do. Scream or cry or destroy this place or herself or just run away.

“Do you want me to go with you?” She-Ra asks sweetly, honest, ready to do anything Catra asks her too just like she promised her.

“No,” Catra snaps, unable to help baring her teeth. “Stay with Queen Sparkles and care for the diplomacy to come to signed terms. I want to get out of here right now.” Catra takes a deep breath, gathering herself of all the pride she can to stop herself from crumbling down. “And keep that man away from me”

“Alright.” She-Ra nods, not even questioning her, not even begging her to come back or to talk about. Caring, so much that it reminds Catra of someone else sometimes.

Catra feels the warmth of She-Ra´s magic leave her side, allowing Catra space to breathe and to calm down. She makes it back to the place where Glimmer has managed to gather more people and speak with them lightheartedly. Catra looks at them all from the corner of her sharp eyes and starts walking again before someone crashes against her, following the heated floors towards the drink aisle.

This is fucked up, so deeply fucked up that she feels the needs to throw up inside her own mouth. Catra doesn´t want to be here a second longer, with these people from the Alliance sneering down at the Wasterians, nor with the latter staring down at Catra herself. She doesn´t want to know about lost kingdoms or lost people or the whisper of a culture that could have been hers if tragedy and war hadn´t fallen over them.

She doesn´t want to know about what she has lost, over and over again beyond her control. Not again, not anymore. She has already lost everything, all that she loved once. She cannot do it again.

Catra reaches the far end of the room and grunts, grasping a glass full of amber liquid and drowning it down in one simple go. It burns in her tongue and throat and tastes like straight up alcohol, something falling between mead and whiskey that makes her nose wrinkle and her mind numb with a deep sigh. Catra hates it the second it touches her lips but she still drinks it full like poison, allowing it to simmer inside her bones and managing to pull some kind of warmth from her bones out.

This part of the chamber is cornered and dark and for some reason it has suddenly gotten especially quiet, still like water long ago untouched and ready to devour if needed. It is so calm that Catra sees it coming the second she notices the change in the air and the sudden smell of drenched sweat. And still, she makes no attempt to move out of the way.

A wide arm runs across her throat and shoulder, locking her in place against the steady torso of a newcomer that holds catra´s body with merciless strength. Their sharp claws dig against Catra ´s shoulder, leaving moon shaped marks on her skin even above the fabric, the angle of their elbow crushing against her windpipe.

It is hard and violent and very quick, a hold done many times before by this kind of mercenary, and yet Catra could still shift herself away from it if she truly wanted. She doesn´t though, mostly because she is going insane a little bit and some because she is bored, giving the person locking Catra inside their arms enough time to press the sharp end of the bone-knife right against the side of her neck, past the chainmail and against her jugular and throat.

“There you are, little Princess,” the rancid voice greets Catra, pressing their breath against the side of her head until her ears flop with annoyance at the feeling. “I was looking for you”

Catra stares at the crumbling wall in front of her and says nothing, leaving the empty glass back on the side. If she narrows her eyes just enough she thinks she would be able to see the long ago erased murals painted over the red dust, of turquoise and jades and bright yellows, a whisper of a kingdom long ago dead inside this place that is a graveyard and a tombstone.

“What? You are not going to react?” The person holding Catra grunts, pressing the knife just a whisper deeper against her skin. The finest of blood drops dribbles from the small wound and down her collarbones, losing itself on her clothes. “Do you even know who I am?”

“I do,” Catra says finally, still unmoving.

She does, of course she does, she remembers all of their faces yet she cannot remember the real name of this one. All that she can remember is that she used to call them Kyle as a fucked up joke and she never learnt their actual name after that. Catra thinks that maybe that's reason enough for them wanting her dead.

“So? Are you going to do something?” the person, not-Kyle, spats with an edge of desperation in their voice, shaking Catra inside their hold so hard that the back of her neck protests with the whiplash. “Aren´t you going to push me away? Aren´t you going to scream for your wife?”

Oh, so that´s it. It´s not only about Catra leaving the people that had learnt to look up to her inside this place just so she could destroy reality and herself in the way. It is about Catra leaving and returning from the hand of the goddess herself, surrounded by her white light and cradled in pearls.

Yes, Catra understands. She would be furious too. She also wished for a long time she could rack her nails through her own throat for betraying herself and her love.

“No,” Catra says, painfully calm, frighteningly quiet. “I would do it too”

Not-Kyle stutters, tilting their head to the side with confusion. They have gotten taller and stronger, they cannot be much older than Catra herself. “What?”

“I would hate me too,” Catra says and she knows it's true the second it leaves her lips. “I would try to kill me too, if I were you.”

It manages to throw off the Wasterian completely, an invisible hit on the chest that they were not expecting. They expected for Catra to put on a fight, a good one. To scream and shout and unfold her claws and fight them back. She is a magnificent warrior, they have seen it with their own eyes. They have been

training exactly for this from the moment the whole Waste found out about the new pretty wife of the golden warrior.

They expected even to not make it out of here alive at all but to endure just enough to slice the traitor´s neck before going down. It has been a dream of theirs, from the moment they were forsaken to this place once the world came back to its axis. Yet here is the so-called Commander, the wife, the redeemed antagonist, leaning back on their hold and looking at some point of the ceiling as if she could not care more if she dropped dead right now. It´s not fair.

"You said you were one of us. A nobody. A wreck." The mercenary spats, losing it little by little. Other Wasterians have started to notice exactly what is going on yet their reactions are almost expected. Surprise, yes, but also a barely hidden whisper of satisfaction, of agreement. They were left behind too, they crave for some sense of justice too, even if uncalled for. "You said that you had lost everything you loved. You gave us hope. Yet in the first opportunity you got you ran back to your Horde and became the She-Ra´s whore."

Catra wants to bend over and throw up or just sink inside her own skin and become one to the sand. She knows the words are as unfair as they are true and she cannot fight them off, but that doesn´t mean they don´t hit the most tender parts of her. That doesn´t mean they do not make her furious, squirming inside her own body with anger.

"I did what I considered best for my people," Catra says between clenched teeth, meeting the eyes of the people of the Waste now gathering in a circle around them.

Their chattering is now whispers quickly passed between each other and even if the music is still playing and the Alliance has not taken notice of anything yet, it will take no time to make it across the entire chamber like wildfire spreading through dry hay.

The mercenary knows this too because they grunt, drawing Catra a few steps backwards and towards the center of the chamber. Not their smartest idea but who knows just exactly what they want. Humiliate Catra, by all means and definitely. Humiliate her in front of people that once followed her and people that will never see her as part of them.

“And how has that been working for you?” The mercenary asks in a sore whisper, pressing their mouth right against Catra´s ears.

Catra wants to rip their eyes out, progressively more and more angry as the seconds go by. The chattering is increasing and the band has stopped playing all together, eyes now glued to the person holding a knife to Catra´s neck. It is humiliating in more than one way, especially when Catra finally meets the eyes of the whole Alliance staring down at her with a new kind of light, annoyance maybe, satisfaction even. Everything is rotten.

“I´m not the one holding a knife to try to avenge the misery,” Catra snaps back, raising her hands and placing them over the mercenary´s arms.

She thinks she can see the glittering trail of Sparkles´ wings making her way through the multitude, followed by Bow, her face contorted in fury. Huntara is close behind, yelling something close to What the fuck do you think you are doing? Drop that fucking knife right now, that Catra doesn´t really care to pay attention to right now. Glimmer however stops in the middle of her furious walkthrough, suddenly frozen for a reason Catra cannot see still.

Catra snaps her eyes away from Sparkles, looking right in front of her instead and that's where she finally sees her again. She-Ra is standing right on the edge of the circle that has formed itself around Catra and the mercenary, looking at the scene with her blazing blue eyes.

She is furious, a tamed wrath that falls short for what Catra sees inside her eyes. It's not like fire, it's worse, like an ocean. Unstoppable, unforgivable, destructive and ripping everything

around itself. Something that cannot be put off no matter what, barely contained by the stone walls of cliffs. She-Ra´s hand is wrapped over the handle of the golden sword hanging from her hip, her knuckles pale like doves where she closes her fingers so violently over the ethereal metal that her bones might just rip off her skin. She is breathing hard, forcefully in a way that raises and falls her chest, boiling mist slipping from the corners of her lips like a dormant dragon.

And she is so, so quiet. So frighteningly unmoving, so calculating in those seconds where Catra takes notice of her that even the people gathered all around her give a step back, gulping heavily at the hovering storm, confused as to why she has not stopped what is happening right now to her so-called wife, terrified by the waves of rotting golden magic leaving off her body like a violent ocean. The statue of a goddess looking to her favorite Priestess.

But Catra knows, without words, in the very marrow of her bones, she knows. Catra meets ice blue eyes and knows She-Ra is holding herself back for her, because of her. She is giving Catra the respect of defending herself and she is giving her the choice. If Catra blinks, if she just breathes differently, She-Ra will step in, but it will be Catra´s choice.

Say the world and I will give it to you.

"You betrayed us so you could slip inside the goddess bed" The knife is now dangerously close to actually leaving a scar on Catra. It would not be her first one and definitely not her last, but it is still painful to bear, it is humiliating to feel. As if she was some kind of victim of the situation. The sting of it makes Catra see red. "So do not play games, bitch."

Quietly, fast as a panther, Catra raises her hands and places them above the mercenary´s wrists, waiting for the split of a second before yanking them to the side harshly. The mercenary gives a surprised gasp, barely realizing what has just happened as their whole body tilts forwards and trips, falling heavily on their knees.

The knife stained in the point with Catra´s blood falls loudly on the unpolished floor, rolling several meters away from them. The mercenary´s eyes follow the movement for a second but they see themself incapable of moving an inch further as Catra´s hand wraps on the low of their chin and tips their whole head backwards, forcing them to see her straight to the eye.

"Who's playing?" Catra says, slow, running the words on her fangs and the back of her throat. Her claws dig slightly over the mercenary´s jaw and the tender point of their neck where their blood runs, threatening to break skin. Catra shakes them in place when they try to pull away, frowning until her eyebrows cast dark shadows over her face. "Stay still. I could slice your tongue out"

The braid has come undone, her hair bouncing below the fine chainmail and opal crown, falling in loops below her waist. Catra has never been much taller than others and favoring leather bands in her feet that allowed her to run faster and slicker instead of shoes had never helped. But right now she looks infinite, big as a star barely contained in the middle of the precarious ballroom. Bigger than the very starship hovering behind the torn curtains.

Nobody inside the chamber is moving, not the Wasterians nor the nobles of the Alliance. Not Bow or Glimmer or Huntara. Not She-Ra. This is about Catra right now and Catra has always known how to defend her own honor higher above anything else.

"I did leave, I know that. I became your leader and then forsaken you all again," Catra starts saying, her voice slipping into the thick accent of the Waste´s language, known to her after spending so long as one of them. Her words are clear and they call to the people of the Waste, staring at her with open eyes. "I left you here, I turned away and never came back. I doomed you, I understand."

The chattering of the Wasterians dies down, every single one of their attentions focusing on her completely. Her accent is slick, practiced, words easy, it doesn't surprise the people of the Waste but it startles the Alliance, their eyes going wide at her voice. It

could be that, maybe, this is the very first time that they realize just how important Catra was, just how brilliant she truly is.

“You hate me, I hate myself too. I broke the world into pieces in return,” Catra gasps, suddenly a little bit out of breath, tangling herself like a killing rope with her own hatred, with her own regret and her own pride.

She clenches her teeth, leaning her face until she is breathing right above the mercenary's eyes before snapping her eyes to everyone inside the room, one by one, Waste and Alliance all the same.

“But you don't get to hurt me, none of you get to touch me ever again. I don´t give a fuck if you call me a traitor or a slut or a princess. I know what I have done but I also know what I am. I am more, and I'm more than what you might deem me unsavable or unworthy. I am more than a piece of flesh for you to feast into.”

Her colorful eyes find Lord Darious among the crowd of people, feline eyes meeting each other. There is something in him, something that Catra carries deep inside the cords of her heart. Some kind of inheritance, like sorrow given from generation to generation, poisoning hope into something toxic like venom.

Catra snaps her sharp teeth together and her pupils close like arrows, holding his eyes and then beyond him the eyes of every single princess in the room. Waste on one side, Royalty on the other, standing over the same ashes. Both of them wrong in all ways possible until the world started crumbling beneath all of their feet.

“I don´t care about your birthright.” Catra spits, biting into her bottom lip until she bleeds herself.

A collective murmur runs from corner to corner of the room but Catra ignores it, blinking to the dim light. She promised to bring freedom to these people, to bring them justice and bring them

vengeance even. Back when she thought destroying herself in the process would bring her peace. All of this wrong is her doing, all of it.

“Then why are you doing this?” someone says among the multitude and Catra cannot place if it is noble blood or stray one but she answers all the same because she has nothing else than this, sincerity and her life.

“For love,” Catra gasps, blinking around her tears. “Isn´t that stupid? The alliance, the marriage, the diplomacy, I did it all for my people. But leaving? Opening that portal? I did it for love and still it was for nothing. I still lost her all over again. I still wanted to die and yet I didn´t, I survived.”

Catra´s nostrils flare with the strength of her breathing, straining in her lungs and the back of her throat. “You don´t get to take that away from me. You don´t get to take the right of my life off my hands, I will do that by myself when I´m done.”

Catra let´s go off the mercenary´s throat, dropping them back into the ground. They fall into an unceremonious bundle of clothes squirming into their hands and knees as they look back at Catra with eyes filled with hatred. Catra stands tall and still in the middle of the old ballroom, showered by the ashes of a home she never got to meet and a home that was ripped away from her.

“The person I love… she is the reason. She wanted a free world. So I'm giving it to her, even if it's coated with my blood.” Catra´s voice is sore but it doesn´t tremble, disrupted like a broken heart. “I will survive just enough to tear Horde Prime´s life off his body, doesn´t matter if you believe me or not.”

The mercenary slams their fist against the floor, growling loudly. They remind Catra a little bit of Double Trouble, another dark stain in her already torn heart, another treason and another heartbreak.

“Fucking liar!”

“I understand, believe me, I do.” Catra´s eyes narrow, her nails digging inside the skin of her palms, running rivers of red around her fingertips. “But that's what I'm going to do. whenever you like it or not, I´m going to give you all a free world and if after you still want to spit in my grave then I will not give a fuck. At least neither Horde Prime, nor Shadow Weaver will be able to take your life either.”

She turns into her ankles, facing away from the mercenary. She does not walk neither to the wasterians nor to the Alliance, instead walking forwards, tethering right in the middle of a world she does not belong to, a world that does not love her in return, feet coated in sand.

Behind her, the mercenary shuffles to their feets and faces her back, holding their breath. They spit in the ground behind her, a gush of saliva and rot that falls against Catra´s red painted ankles, dampening her skin into unforgiven fury.

Catra stops in her steps, exhaling quietly. She doesn´t look back, instead glancing to the side, where golden light and ethereal magic follows her feet like a falcon, searching for her face. Catra exchanges a look with her, She-Ra, full of meaning, a quiet knowledge only they know.

Just say the word.

“Stop it,” someone in the crowd is saying, voice heavy with the language of the Waste, rushing from wall to wall. The words are not directed to her. The shuffling behind Catra has raised, a pair of feet jumping back into a stand, searching for something among the grains of salt and sand. “Wait.”

“Don´t!” someone else screams, sweet with regal knowledge, foreign to Catra yet rushing forward too. A princess, clean magic and frantic voice. “Drop that”

They might be reaching for Catra, they might be reaching for the person behind her, rushed steps that echo with new ones. Another

kind of munity happening inside the crumbling walls of this fallen palace.

Catra is still holding golden eyes in hers. without blinking. The sound of a sharp blade cuts the silence and the sudden screaming, like a fallen bell against the high sing of a frantic chorus. It is light yet heavy at the same time and Catra has lived through enough war to know the mercenary has seized the spear of one of the guards, ripping it out of their hands and into shivering ones, full of acid revenge.

“Don´t you fucking dare!” that´s Sparkles, shouting loudly among the chants, her wings fluttering with anger. Huntara follows her close behind, grunting under her breath. Catra is still holding ethereal eyes in hers, unmoving. It's happening in seconds.

“That´s enough! No.” Very, very slowly, Catra nods, quiet as she blinks and looks away, an affirmation given in secrecy. Permission granted. The sharp spear flying directly towards her chest cuts the air. “No!”

The entire air of the chamber gets sucked off in one motion, drowning everything in silence. The breeze stops, the sound dies down, the waves of sand outside get frightfully still, dunes flattening completely over the earth. Catra can feel the edge of the spear near her twitching ears yet the sharp ends do not reach her at all, stopped in the middle by a second body sheltering her from the blade.

Catra closes her eyes for a second and exhales, very slowly opening them back again and turning around, glancing at the scene happening behind her.

She-Ra is regal and unmoving behind Catra, facing away from her and towards the mercenary. Her short hair moves softly by some kind of fresh breeze that always accompanies her, magic pouring out of her body in white light. She is very quiet in her silence, the sword guarded and hanging from her hip as she extends her right arms, curling her fingers over steel.

She has caught the spear inside her hand, stopping its fly without effort, without sweating, without flinching at all where the blade cuts her palm open and golden ichor drips from the wounds and into the wood handle of the weapon, dripping slowly into the floor. She is unmoving and so is the spear, still trembling in the middle with the strength the mercenary threw the killing blow towards Catra and She-Ra stopped it.

She-Ra is not talking either, not even breathing, staring only with her golden eyes and her golden aura at the mercenary tethering in front of her, with their eyes wide where they had not even seen She-Ra coming.

The ichor from She-Ra´s hands starts sipping inside the steel and wood of the spear, painting it from the inside out, from dark to bright copper and the golden, making it shimmer and boil with ethereal steam as the weapon dissolves into ichor itself and then into nothing, bending itself under the goddess touch and her will.

The mercenary´s breath hitches inside their throat, anger and frustration seizing their bones. And yet, they laugh. Out of desperation or out of raw hatred, they laugh, cackling loudly in the middle of the floor. They don´t even seem to realize they have pissed off a god.

“What are you going to do now, Saint?.” The mercenary spits on the floor again, splashing over She-Ra´s boots.

The mercenary looks past the melting spear and the sand in the floor scattered with golden sparks, past She-Ra herself and her beautiful face and right towards Catra again, their eyes wide and frantic inside their sockets, rimmed by dark bags and red shadows.

It makes Catra hold her breath, suddenly out of balance. It reminds her of someone else, someone she has not seen in a long time, red stares too, poisoned words too, meant to hurt Catra, meant to bend her and manipulate her. Made to break her.

“I do hope she fucks you well. Whore.” They ask, pulling at the strings of her wits.

Catra gasps and curls inside herself as if it had physically struck her, but She-Ra remains quiet. Catra doesn´t even have to look at her now; the sound of her shivering breath is enough for She-Ra to know what she is to do.

She-Ra walks towards him, her long hand wrapping over the handle of her sword. The mercenary follows the movement with their yellow eyes and snickers, grinning at She-Ra sideways, taunting her so-called purity and benevolence. Taunting at her sanctity and immortality, as they believe she will not stain it for the honor of a simple mortal lover.

“What?” They scream at the goddess' face but she doesn´t dignifies to answer them. She doesn´t even dignify breathing in their direction and it makes the mercenary lose it. “What are you going to do for your tramp?”

She does dignify looking into their eyes when she draws her sword, she always looks at every single one of them to the face.

The sword is as golden as everything in her, hard material, made from stardust alone, shimmering with magic, trembling with barely contained power. It is born from sorcery alone, brought to this world from the strings of the goddess by her will alone, a weapon of protection and healing but also of decay, of destruction and rot. It wields a fraction of She-Ra´s power and all of her fury, slicing the fabric of the universe in half.

It is easy for it to slice against flesh.

The crowd inside the ballroom gasps, holding the air inside their chests. Their trembling hearts match the steps of the mercenary as the latter stumbles back over the floor, grasping at the gaping and slick place where their jaw and tongue used to be.

The cut down bone, flesh and muscle tethers down over their clothes and stains the sand floor below with dark blood, extending

where it drips between their fingertips. It is useless, really, it is useless for the mercenary to try and hold their ripped mouth together. It´s not like they will be able to mutter another word ever again.

She-Ra runs her palm over the edge of her blood, cleaning the sticky and fresh blood out of it. Slowly, easily, she doesn´t even look shaken up by this.

"Be quiet now."

She shakes her hand clean, guarding the weapon back to its place again, safely next to her hip, the blue runestone like Catra´s eyes shimmering in white, just a fraction of her true power and a fragment of her anger. Maybe now the kingdoms gathered around her will understand that if a goddess is what they want then they will have one, and goddesses bow to no one.

“I warned you, Huntara.” She says to the Crimson Princess without looking at her, tilting her head to the side as the mercenary falls into the ground and grunts in pain, trying to scream and failing to do so.

She-Ra extends her pale hand stained in red and rests it over the mercenary´s forehead, pressing down as white light pour out of it and into the mercenary´s body, It runs down their veins like thunderbolts and closes veins and arteries, butchered but not bleeding out, a showcase of terrifying power.

It is gruesome, the butcher and the false mercy of the healing. The mercenary squirms and tries to push away but is unable to do so, held down by She-Ra's steel hold and the force of her magic. They try to shout in agony, to beg for mercy but the magic that has always been benevolent is nothing but another kind of suffering, the promise of more if they do not abide by her command.

She-Ra will not kill them because that is not Catra´s wishes. She has always been so fundamentally good. But they will not speak

Catra´s name inside their tongue ever again either.

When she is done she steps back and lets the heavy body fall down again, uninterested in it once again.

"Listen to me now." She-Ra exclaims, calm yet loud, wasterian and etherian equally, overlapping like the voices of all her ancestors before her and yet her own, a war battle that shakes the hearts of everyone with fear and respect.

"Diplomacy is over. Horde Prime will not doubt on murder each and every single one of you when he steps foot on Etheria again. He does not care about this planet, he doesn't care about stupid wars or dumb ballrooms. He doesn´t care about any of you. He will come to exterminate us. If you stand alone, you will die."

Her words fall heavy like an explosion over the entire place, freezing cold. The temperature has plummeted, from unbearable hot to deadly cold, raising fog from everyone´s mouths except for She-Ra and for the one she stands for.

She-Ra tilts her head to the side, meeting Catra´s eyes quietly. She is looking at the mercenary, whittling in pain on the floor next to She-Ra´s feet; at the ripped part of their body and their words now drowned in silence. Her face is blank, her mouth numb but her eyes alive, blazing like an undying fire inside her irises.

She blinks and looks up towards She-Ra, turquoise and amber against melting gold, catching every single one of She-Ra´s gold tears where the amount of magic overwhelms her from the inside out. She follows their tracks down the goddess' impossible face and the hollow of her throat, dripping over the handle of the sword and feels herself untouchable for a second, held above the world by someone she hates. By someone she loves.

She-Ra´s eyes snap suddenly towards the people around them, both Waste and Alliance all the same, holding them all by their souls with the intensity of her gaze.

“You might scream or spit all you want but the only reason any of you are alive at all is because of her, because of her forces at the Horde and her evacuation plans. Because she came back and crawled on the destruction of your homes herself and pulled you down when Prime seeked to murder your families. Because she came back for you.” She-Ra looks at the face of every single one of the Princesses, sewing the meaning of her words inside their chests.

Catra has committed many sins for anger, for sorrow, for love, but she has also done so much good. She crawled out of hell and seeked to repair what she had broken even if she could not repair herself. She has done that, no matter who it is. She-Ra will not allow any of these pompous royals never cut by war to forget that.

She-Ra snaps her face to the Waste now, running her tongue over her teeth where she snarls, magic cracking in her fingertips, almost out of control.

“She protected you all, even at the Horde. She hid your existence and so Prime never knew about you, even though it cost her blood. She has brought you food and medical aid when nobody else in this wretched world even wanted to consider the Valley of the Lost like something worth saving. Except for her. You owe her your life and you owe her your respect”

Catra takes a sharp breath, throwing back her shoulders. She is looking at She-Ra, truly and absolutely looking at her, weighing her in and her words, drinking on the meaning of them. She hates her, despises her, loves her and desires her, seduced by this immortal being so far away from her reach. And here is this goddess, standing in the middle of a room where everyone is an enemy of the next, her words sharp and her golden hands tinted in red. Because of Catra, for Catra.

She has allowed Catra to defend herself and stepped in the places where she couldn´t do it alone, filling the gaps. She is defending Catra´s honor in mouth and body, standing between Catra and

the hatred of this world, speaking of events Catra didn´t even know she knew about, about things Catra has done, good things, tender things. Things meant to protect the people breathing in this world, like a penitence for making it bleed before.

This being who is Catra´s greatest enemy and a thief, who should be the biggest judge of Catra´s sins and who has makes Catra fall in love with her, is speaking in her defense, never in her place but for her, something just one person had ever done before and even then just in secrecy. Putting at risk their war and their whole lives to grant Catra the respect she long ago deserved of.

This life has failed Catra one too many times, and she is ready to reclaim it back with tooth and nail until she has no fight left on her and she can meet Adora on the other side. And here is someone new protecting that right with blood and magic. Yes, Catra´s greatest enemy, loving her back.

"We are winning this war. With or without you." She-Ra grunts and even in her anger it sounds like music, like a vow long ago broken, like pieces of a heart barely kept together. It sounds like a command, it sounds like a promise. "You get to decide if you will live enough to see it happen"

She-Ra turns fully towards Catra and looks at her completely, sword in her waist, power in her veins. She looks at her sea glass and her black clothes and, slowly, bows her head down to her. Respect, granted. Honored.

Catra´s breath dies in her throat and she bites so hard into her own mouth that her fangs bleed her, gathering the iron taste on the back of her tongue. There is movement in the edge of her vision and when she turns her eyes towards the crowd gathered in the ballroom she sees every single pair of eyes placed on her. Not in the immortal warrior they seek for hope, but in Catra´s.

The muttering of her name has died down, either by fear of the saint´s blade or by the sudden devotion of Catra´s heart, the chattering against her becoming something else. Surprised, yes,

still wearing on the edges, but different. They are also seeing her as she truly is, with her chainmails and all of her scars. With her dry blood, with her suffering, with her stubbornness. With her hatred and her love, standing barefoot on the sand of her home.

One by one, little by little, all of the heads and faces bow down towards her. All of them, Waste and Alliance, strays and royalty. The Rebellion, Glimmer, Bow. Lord Darius, the last piece of a past she does not want. She-Ra.

Absently Catra wonders what would Adora have thought of her if she had seen her like this. Absently she thinks she can feel her near, cradled in the marrow of her bones, so close to her soul that it is overwhelming. Always near and always far from reach.

"We will follow you." Huntara says after a long moment of silence, stepping too in the middle of this silence. "Both of you"

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Catra sits in the edge of the precarious window, watching the dunes of the desert rolling over themselves and collapse before making themselves anew.

The Valley of the Lost is quiet after the ballroom, blood smelling and steel sound. She is aware that there are people working in the dunes beyond her sight, already preparing the spaceship to be taken to Brightmoon as soon as the day moon touches Etheria again.

What a foreign concept, space. Spaceship. Stars. Once upon a time all of it was so far away from her, so detached from her life. She did not know about the existence of life beyond the red fog of the Fright Zone nor did she care.

Things have changed so much, for her, for the whole world. Even now, with every step, things seem to be changing for Catra with every breath. She is despised and then worshiped. Spit at and then bow to. So many things, swirling around her head and

beyond her control. It's maddening and she would run away if she didn´t know herself much better.

A shy knock on the door rips her out of sore thoughts, just beyond the metal of her chamber´s door. She turns towards the place where the sound is coming from and exhales, wrinkling her nose.

“Come in”

There was an attempt of murder against her today yet she is not afraid to let her door open, or to wander alone across the dark corridors of this abandoned palace, like she did for hours after the mock of a party finally died down and someone stepped in to clean the blood away. She can still see the slash of the sword against the mercenary´s face beyond her closed eyelids; she can see the burnt murals of the vaults where the history of the magicats will forever remain broken.

She-Ra walks inside Catra´s small chamber, seeking for Catra and finding her immediately. The veil covering her from the sand is gone and so is part of her armor, leaving her only in the ethereal clothes below.

Like this Catra can see the expanse of the pristine skin of her arms and the curve of her neck and not for the first time Catra wonders what it feels to not have scars to carry.

Catra and She-Ra share a look, staring at each other without approaching further. She-Ra lingers on the corner of the bed, her fingers twitching at her sides, almost as if there was something she wanted to reach and was holding herself back with all her might.

Catra remains in her place in the window, mouth pressed against her bent knees, gathering the gold of She-Ra´s magic inside her chest. There are so many things she should say right now.

She should scream, she should shout at this being how stupid she was, how dangerous what she did was, challenging entire nations

only for the sake of Catra´s honor. She should grab her silk clothes and make her bend the knee, look up at Catra´s eyes and demand why, why would she do it, why would she give everything to Catra when nothing has been granted in return.

She should thank her, she should release the breath inside her lungs and say she was scared, actually scared. That she has wanted to die for so long and has almost done so many times yet for some reason she was actually scared, refusing to understand that her life could be ripped out of her yet again, beyond her control.

She should place her mouth against the goddess and press her tongue against her teeth. She should lick a line over the roof of her mouth and gasp against her touch and sink inside the faux sense of safety that this saint has seemed to make her own to give her. As if this way she could compensate for the heartbreak inside Catra´s heart, as if this way she could fix the unfixable.

Catra should do a lot of things, all of them more dangerous than the next but she refuses them all, instead rolling other words inside her tongue and placing them in the space between them.

"The magicat ambassador said there was a daughter of the Halfmoon Empress that was taken away from them before the Erasure. Before she was murdered by the Horde." Catra says, narrowing her eyes. She repeats the words just as she heard them for the first time, listening to the quiet man murmuring quiet words to her in the safety of the corridor. "He sees resemblance."

She-Ra knows a great deal about loss. She was ripped away from the place that saw her be born and then was torn apart from the place that saw her grow. She was torn apart from her only love and was torn apart by her own soul. She has lost everything and then she has lost the only thing, the only person that mattered to her, beyond anything else.

There is indeed a great loss inside of She-Ra´s heart and so she understands, even if they cannot understand each other, she

understands this side of Catra as she has always done.

“What do you believe?” She-Ra asks in a murmur, regarding Catra with intelligence, with patience, trying to let her know that no matter who she is or who she could have been, it does not shape who she can choose to be now. She-Ra wishes, now more than ever, that Catra could read her like before.

“I think he believes what he needs to in order to survive.” Catra whispers, narrowing her eyes until the colorful irises are only sparks of light.

“And do you want it?” Careful, whatever Catra wants she will have it. Catra does not want anything though.

“No. I am nobody's daughter.”

It is still her, still Catra, the very same She-Ra has loved from the very dawn of the universe, the only one capable of carrying She-Ra´s heart inside her crumbling heart and doing everything right because she is her only owner.

“Then you don´t need to accept it. You don´t have to be anything you don´t want.”

Maybe Catra can read her, after all.

Catra blinks, very slow, holding She-Ra´s eyes the whole time. Her tail stomps softly over the seat of the crooked window and that is all that She-Ra needs to move forward, standing inside Catra´s essence but still a breath away, enough to not be able to touch her at all.

“Where were you?” Catra inquiries, looking at the lightness of She-Ra´s dressing.

The stupid tiara is gone and the waist of her pants cradles her hips, molding her shape into something incapable of not looking at. Today her eyes are a special kind of golden and, even in the middle of the fucking desert, she looks like a living oasis.

“I just needed a second”

Holding She-Ra for so long makes Adora suffer. That is a truth Adora learnt very early and very young. Now she is older but that has never been easier for her, no matter how thin she stretches herself.

And every single time after such a long time, the human underneath She-Ra's skin has to hide into the most miserable and dark corner of abandoned places and cry herself raw until she feels like she can hold herself together a few seconds more.

Catra does not know that though. She narrows her eyes and leans forward, softly sniffing a line at the level of She-Ra's neck. She curls over She-Ra's neck, draping herself like a second skin over her chest.

She wraps her palms against the base of She-Ra's nape and presses the tip of her nose and the curve of her mouth on the space between She-Ra's collarbones and jaw and draws a line against her skin, heavy, scent marked.

It's borderline possessive, the motion, as if she was looking for traces of someone else in She-Ra's skin. It's unhealthy, obsessive. She-Ra drinks on it.

“I was starting to think you had taken notice of all the beautiful women hawking for you,” Catra growls against She-Ra's neck, ghosting the tip of her damp lips over the base of her ears.

She-Ra allows her own nose and mouth to tilt towards Catra's hair and gathers Catra's smell in the back of her throat, relishing in it, her mouth watering immediately. Catra always smells so good, it is in her hair and the roots of her ears, living in the corners of her skin where sweat and flush meet.

She does not touch her though, not without Catra´s permission. Instead She-Ra lets her head fall backwards, marble neck exposed for Catra to curl into if she wants, looking at the stars scattered beyond the window.

“Why would I?” she asks, sore even to her ears. Catra nips the angle of She-Ra´s jaw with her fangs and her nails dig softly over her skin, ripping scratches that heal immediately, holding her in place.

“You are She-Ra. You could have anyone.”

There is no denial in the venom in Catra's voice, the anger, the slick jealousy towards phantom people occupying her wife's bed. It should be terrifying for She-Ra but it only makes her on edge, boiling hot from the inside out, tilting over the careful line she has drawn between them and over her own heart. Mutiny happening inside of her own soul, divided between love and duty.

“I could,” she hears Catra take a sharp breath, a cold shiver running down her spine. She-Ra's hands ache to hold her. “But I don´t want to”

“Why?” Catra is pressing it, she needs to hear it, she needs to feel belonging and so does She-Ra. She has denied Catra so much already, she can at least give her this.

“I'm sworn to, already.” She-Ra tilts her head down, catching Catra´s blazing eyes inside hers. She is so tall even with Catra sitting over the window they are both eye to eye, heart to heart. “I belong to you already.”

Catra´s eyes darken like an ocean, her jaw growing slack. She stares at She-Ra´s face, nails drawing pink and golden lines down her throat and the hollow of her collarbone, past the ethereal fabric of her clothes and all the way across She-Ra´s shoulder blades, holding her closer.

“Please allow me to touch you,” She-Ra whispers in the thread of a voice, unable to hold herself back anymore.

Catra licks her lips damp and nods, halfway through a growl, halfway through a plea. They push and pull from each other and tear the world apart in the middle.

“Yes”

Catra does not know, she does not understand, that She-Ra is furious, livid. That adrenaline and hatred curses down her veins and boils the chambers of her heart. That she can still smell the lingering sweat of the mercenary in Catra´s hair; that she can see the faint spirit of the blade against her throat. Catra does not understand that She-Ra would have pulled them apart bone by bone if she had wanted, that she would do it once and thrice and a thousand times again if Catra were to say the word.

She-Ra would never forsake the world but beneath this ethereal skin, Adora would break it into pieces for her.

She-Ra slips between her legs, nudging Catra´s knees against the divots of her waist. She slips her palms across the side of Catra´s waist, her fingers over the crevices of her spine, pushing dark fabric away. Catra shivers inside her palms and She-Ra holds her even closer, pushing their chests together.

Catra smells incredible, She-Ra is intoxicated by it, by the softness of Catra´s body beneath this immortal skin and the way it raises goosebumps on her nape and the length of her arms. She-Ra did not know she could adore Catra more than she does now, she did not know that she could worship her ever again and yet here it is, presented with the only thing she cannot have.

“You certainly don´t know,” She-Ra whispers, leaning her forehead against Catra´s, pressing their skins together. Catra exhales, flattening her palms over the expanse of her back.

“What?”

“How much I hold you dear”

They are so close to each other that they share the same air, the same breath. She-Ra can feel Catra´s fluttering heartbeat in her fingertips, the frail edge of her bones and the smell of her neck. The way she looks back at her as if she despised her and adored her at the same time.

“And still, you won´t lay in bed with me?”

She-Ra has never told Catra that she loves her back, never, not even once. Yet here she is, undoing herself for her, giving her the world inside her palms and marching to war for her.

She has never told her she loves her, she can´t.

“No,” She-Ra shakes her head, closing her eyes, pressing her cold cheek against Catra´s warm one. “I can´t”

“Why not?”

Because I love you. Because I won´t be able to control myself if I have you in my arms.

She-Ra has never told Catra she loves her because Catra is going to lose her all over again. She cannot do that to her, not again. She cannot deliver herself fully and bloom inside the freckles of her hands just to rot in her palms right after.

Adora is already dead and She-Ra is the tale of a martyr. And no matter how much Catra thinks she loves She-Ra, no matter how much She-Ra adores her in return, she is not ripping the hope of a happy future away from Catra, ever again.

“It is my way of honoring you,” She-Ra confesses because that is the only thing she can give. “Will you accept it?”

There is something inside of Catra that knows that She-Ra keeps something from her. Something important, vital. Heartbreaking. The very same part of her heart that loves her, that wants her alive, that cannot live without her; the very same part that wants the stars and She-Ra´s breath. The very same that keeps her alive.

There is something inside of Catra that wants to scream, something that is Adora´s alone, all of it, molded in the shape of her hands and the edge of her laughter. These parts meet each

other and collide and they make Catra new and they make She-Ra cry.

“Kiss me,” Catra says and She-Ra complies. Teeth clashing, tongues meeting, tears on each other´s cheeks. “Again.” Exhales on throats, fingers over skin and lips brushing in strokes. “Again”

They kiss each other on the edge of that crooked window, ignoring blood and anger and resentment. Ignoring the stars and the looming green shade above them. Ignoring royalty and death and extermination. Ignoring destiny or inheritance, all of it except each other.

“Do you still want to die?” She-Ra paints with her mouth over Catra´s cheeks, holding her up, keeping her from falling into the void again.

“I don´t know.” She wants to be with Adora, she wants to be with She-Ra. She wants to tear her soul in pieces and give a fragment to each and the rest to the universe and the sea. She wants nothing, she wants everything. “You would kill for me and you would die for me. Would you live for me?”

“I don´t know,” She-Ra wants to stop existing, Adora is screaming for living. She wants to strip bare of her skin and step in the sand of the shore and become stardust herself. Whenever she can meet Catra as she is again. “It doesn´t matter what I want. Dreams are not reality, Catra.”

Catra opens her eyes at the desert night and looks at the stars through strands of golden hair, holding herself to the impossible. Maybe they can keep each other alive, maybe they are both going to die in the end. Maybe, just maybe, no matter the end, Catra won´t be alone this time.

“We can make them,” She-Ra presses her lips against her cheek and Catra shivers. “Isn´t that the whole reason why we are living?”

——— ⋆·☆·⋆ ———

(...) I'd promise you the world
To show the lengths that I adore you
I'd cross the world back over
There's no ship I wouldn't board (...)
(...) And I'll drag the world up by the neck
And place it out before you
— **Sunken**, *Colm R. McGuinness*

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!

The third part "Sanctuary" is already in the works, and I think is being time for all of you to know where has Shadow Weaver been doing this whole time. Please be patient!

Kudos, comments and bookmarks are deeply appreciated. Please remember not to upload this or any of my stories anywhere else without permission. Have a good day and be good people! <3

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